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INFLUENCE OF DIGITAL MARKETING STRATEGIES ON CUSTOMER ENGAGEMENT IN ONLINE RETAIL PLATFORMS

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ABSTRACT:

The rapid growth of e-commerce and digital technology has transformed retail marketing, making digital strategies essential for customer engagement. This study examines the influence of social media marketing, email marketing, SEO, content marketing, and influencer marketing on consumer engagement in online stores. A quantitative survey of 97 online shoppers was conducted using a structured Likert-scale questionnaire, with data analysed through SPSS using correlation and regression techniques. The findings show that social media marketing, email marketing, SEO, and content marketing have significant positive effects on consumer engagement, while influencer marketing shows a positive but statistically insignificant relationship. The overall model explains 50.3% of the variation in consumer engagement, highlighting the importance of integrated digital marketing strategies for building customer engagement and brand relationships.

Keywords: *Digital Marketing, Customer Engagement, Online Retail, Social Media Marketing, Search Engine Optimization*

Introduction

Over the last ten years, the global e-commerce industry has grown at an unparalleled rate. By 2026, online retail sales throughout the globe are expected to reach more than $8.1 trillion (Statista, 2024). As the internet marketplace becomes more congested, businesses are looking for new methods to get respondents's attention, which has led to a huge change in how digital marketing is done. The integration of big data analytics, artificial intelligence, and social media platforms has established a framework for targeted, personalised, and widespread dissemination of marketing messages, significantly transforming the dynamics between brands and consumers (Chaffey & Ellis-Chadwick, 2022).

Customer involvement has become a fundamental concept in modern marketing theory and practice. Customer engagement is different from conventional measurements like sales conversion rates since it includes a wide range of cognitive, emotional, and behavioural interactions that customers experience with a business (Brodie et al., 2011). High levels of engagement are linked to more loyal customers, better word-of-mouth, less price sensitivity, and a higher lifetime value for customers (Hollebeek et al., 2014; Vivek et al., 2012). In the realm of online shopping, where customers are inundated with thousands of digital stimuli everyday, the efficacy of digital marketing tactics to cultivate and maintain significant engagement has emerged as a critical issue for both practitioners and scholars.

Even if there is more and more research on digital marketing and e-commerce, there is still a big vacuum in empirical studies that look at more than one digital marketing channel and how they affect consumer engagement. Numerous studies have investigated singular tactics, such social media marketing (Kim & Ko, 2012; Stelzner, 2023) and email marketing (Ramos & Young, 2009), in isolation, failing to provide a comprehensive, comparative study within a cohesive empirical framework. Furthermore, most of the studies that have been done so far have been in Western markets, and not enough research has been done on how different demographic groups are using digital technology (Tuten & Solomon, 2021).

This study fills these gaps by looking at how five well-known digital marketing strategies—social media marketing, email marketing, search engine optimisation, content marketing, and influencer marketing—affect customer engagement in online retail, both together and on their own. Utilising a quantitative survey approach with a sample of 97 active online consumers, the study elucidates the intricate processes by which digital marketing campaigns influence customer behaviour and engagement results.

The research analyses the distinct impact of social media marketing, email marketing, SEO, content marketing, and influencer marketing on customer engagement within online retail platforms; to evaluate the overall

explanatory efficacy of the chosen digital marketing strategies on customer engagement; and to determine the most impactful digital marketing strategy among those examined.

The results of this investigation have important theoretical and practical consequences. From a theoretical perspective, the study enhances the expanding corpus of information about the precursors of consumer involvement in digital retail environments. The combined analysis of five digital marketing tactics inside a singular empirical model offers a more nuanced and thorough comprehension of their interactions and their cumulative influence on customer behaviour. The report offers practical suggestions for digital marketing managers, e-commerce entrepreneurs, and brand strategists aiming to enhance their marketing efforts and maximise consumer engagement results.

Literature Review

Over the past 20 years, there has been considerable research interest in the links between digital marketing strategies and customer engagement in online retail, as a result of the profound ways in which digital technologies have reshaped consumer-brand relationships. Digital marketing is generally defined as the deployment of online channels, data-driven insights, and interactive media to target and influence a consumer audience, and its success is increasingly evaluated in terms of customer engagement - a complex construct that incorporates cognitive, emotional and behavioural engagement with a brand (Chaffey & Ellis-Chadwick, 2022; Hollebeek et al., 2014). The first to operationalise the concept of customer engagement in a service-dominant logic framework, Brodie et al. (2011) contend that customer engagement goes beyond transactional measures and is an expression of relational bonds with brands. In e-commerce, such bonds are built and nurtured through ongoing digital interactions, and the nature and effectiveness of these interactions are influenced by the marketing activities that companies undertake (Lemon & Verhoef, 2016). Social media marketing is one of the most effective of these; Kim and Ko's (2012) study found that social media marketing activities - in particular, entertainment, interaction, trendiness, customisation and word-of-mouth - have a significant positive effect on brand equity and purchase intentions for consumers. Building on this research, Hollebeek et al. (2014) created and validated a scale of consumer brand engagement in social media environments, confirming that the level of engagement positively influences brand loyalty and negates price sensitivity. Tuten and Solomon (2021) also contended that the affordances of social media that facilitate participation and community building make these platforms particularly well-suited to engage consumers in ways that are conducive to longer-term engagement, as consumers themselves co-produce brand marketing by sharing and commenting on user-generated content. Additionally, search engine optimization (SEO) has long been identified as a key enabler of organic website traffic and user discovery; Jansen and Spink (2006)

observed the explicit behavioral bias of users to click and engage with organic search results, rather than paid ads, which translates into increased engaged, goal-oriented traffic. Ryan (2020) consolidated current SEO practice as the intersection of technical, content and consumer experience design considerations, which when combined reduce friction in the consumer path to action and increase engagement. Similarly, email marketing has continued to be a high-value channel, and Xu et al. (2020) confirmed that behaviorally targeted, personalised email marketing results in much higher engagement than broadcast-style email, because of its ability to provide relevant information at the most opportune times.

A second major body of work relates to the use of content marketing and influencer marketing as supplementary consumer engagement strategies, as well as theoretical insights that provide context to how and why digital marketing initiatives are effective in obtaining consumer engagement. Pulizzi (2014) defined content marketing as the strategic creation and dissemination of valuable, non-promotional information intended to attract and retain a specific audience, and Holliman and Rowley (2014) confirmed that content marketing is an effective approach in the B2C space, with informative and trust-building content having a significant impact on consumer purchasing decisions and ongoing brand engagement. Rose and Pulizzi (2011), further argued that content marketing is a relationship-building tool that converts the consumer-brand relationship from transactional to conversational in a way that is well aligned with online retailing, where the consumer can easily compare and disassociate. In contrast, influencer marketing uses parasocial relationships between social media influencers and their audience to convey credibility, and drive engagement with a brand (Freberg et al., 2011). Lou and Yuan (2019) reported that perceived informativeness and credibility of influencer-provided branded content significantly affected consumer trust and engagement, but De Veirman et al. (2017) warned that a large following base does not necessarily ensure high quality engagement with the influencer, with the fit between the product and influencer and authenticity playing an important role. Djafarova and Rushworth (2017) also reported that female consumers are more likely to be affected by micro-influencers who are perceived as authentic and relatable, rather than by celebrity endorsements, suggesting the segment-specific nature of influencer marketing. Theoretically, the stimuli-organism-response (S-O-R) model offers a conceptual framework that integrates the role of digital marketing stimuli, such as social media postings, email communications, search engine optimisation (SEO) derived website experiences, website content and influencer promotion, as environmental cues that evoke cognitive and affective responses, which subsequently lead to specific engagement responses, such as purchasing, review writing, sharing and returning visits to the website (Kotler et al., Although there is extensive research on this topic, Chaffey (2023) observed that empirical studies that simultaneously consider multiple channels of digital marketing in a single analytical

framework are still relatively scarce, and Ryan (2020) stressed the need for evidence that can determine the relative importance of each channel so that practitioners can invest with greater certainty. This study directly addresses this shortcoming by considering five prominent digital marketing strategies in a unified multiple regression approach, providing new insights for both theory and practice within the expanding field of digital marketing.

Methodology

Research Design

This research used a quantitative, cross-sectional survey methodology to examine the impact of digital marketing techniques on consumer interactions with online retailers. The research was guided by a positivist epistemological framework, consistent with the objective of assessing pre-established hypotheses via empirical data collection and statistical analysis (Bryman, 2016). The cross-sectional method was used to gather consumer perspectives and experiences at a particular point in time, facilitating the analysis of correlations among the study variables.

Population and Sampling

Respondents who were 18 years old or older and had purchased anything from an online retailer in the past six months were the target audience. Because of time and access constraints, a convenience sample strategy, augmented by purposive screening, was used. There were 97 valid replies in the final sample, which is more than the minimal number of participants required for multiple regression analysis with five predictors. Field (2018) suggests that there should be at least 15 to 20 participants per predictor variable.

Instrument Development

A systematic, self-administered questionnaire based on validated measures in the current literature was used to collect data. The questionnaire has two primary elements. Part A asked for demographic information such gender, age group, level of education, and how frequently they buy things online. In Section B, there were 30 Likert-scale questions (1 = Strongly Disagree to 5 = Strongly Agree) that asked individuals what they thought about five digital marketing methods and how they attracted respondents to take part. The social media marketing scale was taken from Kim and Ko (2012), the email marketing scale from Xu et al. (2020), the SEO scale from Enge et al. (2015), the content marketing scale from Holliman and Rowley (2014), the influencer marketing scale from Lou and Yuan (2019), and the customer engagement scale from Hollebeek et al. (2014).

Validity and Reliability

Three marketing academics checked the scale parts to make sure they were clear, relevant, and thorough. This proved that the material was good. We performed confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) to check the validity of the concept. All factor loadings above the recommended threshold of 0.60 (Hair et al., 2019). To verify for internal consistency dependability, the Cronbach's alpha coefficient was utilised. The alpha values for all of the subscales were over 0.80, which means that the findings were trustworthy. For example, the alpha value for Social Media Marketing was 0.867, for Email Marketing it was 0.841, for SEO it was 0.853, for Content Marketing it was 0.838, for Influencer Marketing it was 0.812, and for Customer Engagement it was 0.891.

Data Collection Procedure

An online survey tool was used to gather the data across four weeks. The survey link was given out via email, social media, and online retail community forums that were targeted for a certain set of individuals. Everyone who took part in the study provided their informed consent before the data was collected, and their identity was protected to avoid social desirability bias. Before the major investigation, a pilot test with 15 respondents was done to assess how clear the instrument was. A few words were altered based on what respondents said. To be included, respondents had to claim they had used at least one online shopping site in the last six months.

Data Analysis Techniques

SPSS was employed to analyse the data comprehensively. The analytical strategy comprised several stages: (1) descriptive statistics, including means, standard deviations, and frequency distributions, to delineate the sample and variable distributions; (2) Pearson product-moment correlation analysis to examine bivariate relationships among study variables; (3) multiple linear regression analysis to evaluate the hypothesised relationships and the explanatory efficacy of digital marketing strategies on customer engagement; and (4) one-way ANOVA to assess overall model fit. We used variance inflation factors (VIF) and tolerance levels to check for multicollinearity. All of the VIF values were less than 5.0, which meant that there was no multicollinearity that may create difficulties.

Analysis and Interpretaion

Demographic Profile of Respondents

Table 1 displays the survey results for the 97 persons who took it. The majority were male (55.7%), and the predominant age cohort was 25 to 34 years (36.1%). A bachelor's degree was held by 46.4% of them, and 40.2% of them shopped online once a week. Respondents who purchase online a lot usually have these features.

Table 1: Demographic Profile of Respondents (N = 97)

Variable	Category	Frequency (%)
Gender	Male	54 (55.7%)
	Female	43 (44.3%)
Age Group	18-24 years	28 (28.9%)
	25-34 years	35 (36.1%)
	35-44 years	22 (22.7%)
	45 years and above	12 (12.4%)
Education Level	High School	10 (10.3%)
	Undergraduate	45 (46.4%)
	Postgraduate	32 (33.0%)
	Others	10 (10.3%)
Shopping Frequency	Daily	18 (18.6%)
	Weekly	39 (40.2%)
	Monthly	28 (28.9%)
	Rarely	12 (12.4%)

The demographic distribution shows that the sample is typical of online shoppers: they are young to middle-aged respondents with a college degree who are comfortable with technology. The modal group's weekly purchasing frequency indicates a moderate-to-high level of involvement with online retail platforms, making the sample suitable for this study's objectives.

Descriptive Statistics

Table 2 shows the descriptive statistics for all the research variables. Social media marketing had the highest average score (M = 4.12, SD = 0.71), followed by customer involvement (M = 4.08, SD = 0.68) and SEO (M = 4.05, SD = 0.76). Influencer marketing had the lowest average score (M = 3.74, SD = 0.92), which means that respondents thought it was a good idea, but they thought it was a little less successful than the other techniques.

Table 2: Descriptive Statistics of Study Variables (N = 97)

Variable	Mean	SD	Median
Social Media Marketing	4.12	0.71	4.00
Email Marketing	3.89	0.84	4.00
Search Engine Optimization	4.05	0.76	4.00
Content Marketing	3.97	0.79	4.00
Influencer Marketing	3.74	0.92	4.00
Customer Engagement	4.08	0.68	4.00

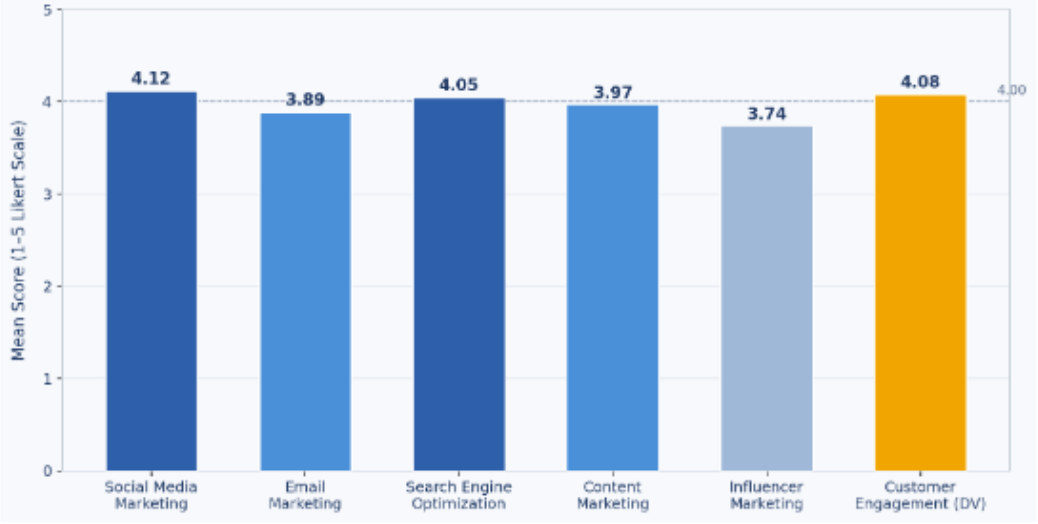


Fig 1: Comparative mean scores of Digital Marketing Strategy Variables

Pearson Correlation Analysis

We used Pearson product-moment correlation analysis to look at the bivariate correlations between all of the research variables. All five digital marketing methods showed statistically significant positive connections with consumer involvement at the $p < .01$ level. There was the strongest link between social media marketing ($r = .672$, $p < .001$), content marketing ($r = .654$, $p < .001$), and SEO ($r = .639$, $p < .001$). Email marketing ($r = .621$, $p < .001$) and influencer marketing ($r = .538$, $p < .001$) also showed moderate to strong positive links to consumer involvement. Table 3 shows the matrix of correlations between the predictor variables.

Table 3: Pearson Correlation Matrix of Predictor Variables

Variable	SMM	EM	SEO	CM	IM

Social Media Marketing (SMM)	1.000	0.631**	0.572**	0.614**	0.489**
Email Marketing (EM)	0.631**	1.000	0.543**	0.578**	0.452**
SEO	0.572**	0.543**	1.000	0.601**	0.421**
Content Marketing (CM)	0.614**	0.578**	0.601**	1.000	0.513**
Influencer Marketing (IM)	0.489**	0.452**	0.421**	0.513**	1.000

** Correlation is significant at the 0.01 level (2-tailed). SMM = Social Media Marketing; EM = Email Marketing; CM = Content Marketing; IM = Influencer Marketing.

Multiple Linear Regression Analysis

We used multiple linear regression to look at how the five digital marketing tactics affected consumer engagement. The whole model was statistically significant ($F(5, 91) = 18.431$, $p < .001$), and it accounted for 50.3% of the variation in customer involvement (R-squared = .503, Adjusted R-squared = .478). Table 4 shows the regression coefficients.

Table 4: Multiple Linear Regression Coefficients -- Predictors of Customer Engagement

Predictor	B	Std. Error	Beta	t-value	p-value
(Constant)	0.412	0.214	--	1.925	.058
Social Media Marketing	0.289	0.071	0.312	4.071	.000***
Email Marketing	0.198	0.068	0.245	2.912	.004***
SEO	0.224	0.073	0.251	3.068	.003***
Content Marketing	0.175	0.069	0.204	2.536	.013**
Influencer Marketing	0.133	0.072	0.180	1.847	.068

*** $p < 0.01$; ** $p < 0.05$. Note: Dependent variable = Customer Engagement.

Social media marketing was the best way to get customers to interact (Beta = 0.312, $t = 4.071$, $p < .001$). SEO (Beta = 0.251, $t = 3.068$, $p = .003$), email marketing (Beta = 0.245, $t = 2.912$, $p = .004$), and content marketing

(Beta = 0.204, t = 2.536, p = .013) were next best. Influencer marketing was linked to more consumer involvement, but it didn't approach statistical significance (Beta = 0.180, t = 1.847, p = .068). There were no problems with multicollinearity since all of the VIF values were below 3.0 (range: 1.82–2.74).

Table 5: ANOVA Table -- Regression Model Fit

Model	Sum of Squares	df	Mean Square	F-value	Sig.
Regression	24.312	5	4.862	18.431	.000***
Residual	23.986	91	0.264	--	--
Total	48.298	96	--	--	--

Fig 2: Standardized Beta Coefficients for Digital Marketing Predictors of Customer Engagement

Discussion

The Primary of Social Media Marketing

The discovery that social media marketing has the most significant effect on consumer involvement (Beta = 0.312) is in line with and builds on previous research in this area. Kim and Ko (2012) established that social media marketing activities such as entertainment, interactivity, trendiness, customisation, and word-of-mouth had a substantial impact on brand equity and purchase intentions. The current research bolsters this corpus of data while expanding it to the particular domain of consumer involvement in online shopping. The interactive capabilities of social media platforms—especially those that enable two-way conversation, user-generated content, and community building—seem to be especially strong drivers of the multidimensional engagement construct. The mean score for social media marketing (M = 4.12) is also rather high, which means that respondents who shop online are well aware of and open to social media marketing efforts.

Search Engine Optimization and Organic Discovery

The fact that SEO has a statistically significant effect on customer involvement (Beta = 0.251) shows how important it is for customers to see your site in organic search results. This study supports the research of Jansen and Spink (2006) and Fishkin and Hogenhaven (2013), which showed that respondents are more likely to trust and prefer search results that are ranked naturally over sponsored ads. Investing in SEO for online stores means getting better website traffic. Customers who come via organic search have shown interest through their searches, which makes them more likely to interact with the site. Modern SEO techniques that

focus on high-quality content, fast page load times, mobile responsiveness, and structured data markup seem to improve the user experience as a whole. This leads to more engagement, such as longer session times and more interaction with product listings (Ryan, 2020).

Email Marketing in the Digital Engagement Ecosystem

Email marketing had a big impact on consumer engagement (Beta = 0.245), showing that it is still useful even when other channels are becoming more popular. This result is in line with what Chaffey (2023) and Xu et al. (2020) found: personalised email marketing may keep respondents interested and get them to come back. Transactional emails, cart abandonment campaigns, personalised product suggestions, and communications about reward programs are all very important parts of the client lifecycle in online retail. The reasonably high mean score for email marketing (M = 3.89) indicates that consumers see email as a successful medium; yet, aspects of email weariness may diminish its efficacy compared to more engaging platforms like social media (Pavlov et al., 2018).

Content Marketing as a Trust-Building Mechanism

The substantial impact of content marketing on consumer engagement (Beta = 0.204) highlights the persistent importance of instructional and educational material in e-commerce. This aligns with the perspectives of Pulizzi (2014) and Holliman and Rowley (2014), who defined content marketing as a strategy for establishing brand authority, fostering customer trust, and promoting enduring relational engagement. In online shopping, product evaluations, buyer guides, comparative articles, and how-to videos serve two purposes: they help real customers while also providing more digital touchpoints that strengthen the brand-consumer connection. The increasing customer inclination towards brand authenticity underscores the significance of content marketing (Rose & Pulizzi, 2011).

Influence Marketing: A Nuanced Picture

The result that influencer marketing did not reach statistical significance (Beta = 0.180, p = .068) is one of the most subtle results of this research. This contrasts with previous studies by Lou and Yuan (2019) and De Veirman et al. (2017), which identified substantial correlations between influencer marketing and customer purchase intentions. There are a few possible reasons for this observation. First, influencer marketing doesn't work the same way for everyone. It depends a lot on the influencer's specialisation, the demographics of their following, and how real they seem. Second, increasing consumer scepticism about sponsored content may reduce the persuasive effect of influencer endorsements (Djafarova & Rushworth, 2017). Third, the sample size (N = 97) may have made it harder to find the small impact size that comes with influencer marketing.

Theoretical and Practical Implications

Theoretically, this research enhances the digital marketing and consumer behaviour literature by providing a comprehensive analysis of five digital marketing methods. The findings both support and contest existing theoretical frameworks, particularly in the context of influencer marketing, thereby facilitating opportunities for future theoretical enhancement. In practice, the results provide online retail marketing managers useful advice on what to do. It seems that putting social media marketing, SEO, and email marketing at the top of the list for financial considerations is a good idea. Content marketing may not have the biggest short-term impact, but it shouldn't be ignored since it may help develop trust over time. To gain good results from influencer marketing, you may need to use a highly focused, niche-specific approach that focuses on authenticity and a real match between the product and the audience.

Conclusion

This research examined the impact of digital marketing techniques on consumer involvement inside online retail platforms, using a quantitative survey approach with 97 participants. The empirical data convincingly illustrate that digital marketing techniques have a formidable collective influence on consumer engagement, with the comprehensive regression model accounting for over 50% of the variation in engagement outcomes. Social media marketing was the most important single predictor, showing how deeply social media has become a part of modern internet commerce. Search engine optimisation and email marketing were very close behind, showing that organic search exposure and direct, personalised communication are still very important tools in digital marketing. material marketing, albeit having a relatively little impact, was nonetheless a statistically significant factor in engagement. This shows that useful and genuine brand material will always be valuable. The lack of importance in influencer marketing, although somewhat unexpected given current industry stories, adds depth to the debate over how successful influencer marketing is. It suggests that its effects may be more tailored to the situation and the audience than most respondents think. These results suggest that a digital marketing strategy that uses several channels and balances reach, personalisation, and authenticity is the best way to go. Future research need to include longitudinal designs, varied cultural settings, and objective behavioural data in conjunction with self-report measures to provide a more thorough understanding of digital marketing efficacy in online retail. This research provides significant practical and theoretical insights that enhance the growing body of knowledge at the convergence of digital marketing, consumer behaviour, and e-commerce.

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